

Exploring a Voluntary, Source-Linked Sworn-Record Format

An AI-assisted discussion paper for Digital Ground Game

- + A plain-language explanation of the proposal and the notary's limited role
- + A fictional example showing the proposed record and correction model
- + Reasons the idea may be worth testing, together with its legal and empirical limits
- + The specific questions on which reviewer feedback is requested

AI-assisted discussion draft for recipient review only. Internal review found changes required; not DGG-approved, counsel-approved, or launch-cleared. Not legal advice. Current Phase 0 permits fictional/tabletop work only - no real signer, oath, notarial act, candidate outreach, recruitment, or live interview. Authority cutoff: August 30, 2026.

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Content assembled from the project research repository.

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How to use this attachment

This attachment is designed to make the underlying idea easy to evaluate. It does not ask the recipient to adopt the legal conclusions, recruit a participant, sign a statement, or perform a notarial act. Independent Washington counsel should review the exact facts, form, script, consent process, and public claims before any real-world activity.

Part I - Executive Brief

The proposal

Political interviews mix checkable facts with predictions, opinions, values, advocacy, humor, and rhetoric. This project asks a narrow question: could a willing speaker make a few suitable factual commitments easier to inspect by placing their exact words, knowledge basis, cited sources, version, and later corrections into a stable record?

If a later phase were approved, the speaker would retain three meaningful choices:

1. put a narrow factual statement into a sworn record;
2. discuss the subject in ordinary unsworn conversation; or
3. qualify the answer, say “I do not know,” or decline the question or format.

DGG would draw and publish no adverse inference from nonparticipation. Because third-party political reactions cannot be controlled, Phase 0 publishes no invitation, participation, refusal, or nonresponse status.

What the notary would - and would not - do

The signer declares the final statement true under oath. The notary checks required identity and signature, administers the oath or affirmation, and completes the notarial certificate.

The notary does **not** investigate the source material, decide whether the political claim is true, predict a crime, or become DGG's spokesperson. The record would preserve provenance and an exact commitment; it would not carry a “true” badge.

A fictional example

Prompt: “As of 5:00 p.m. Pacific time on August 1, 2026, did the fictional Pine County Project ledger attached as Source A record exactly three payments from Example Vendor totaling \$12,450?” **Selected response:** Yes. **Final statement:** “As of 5:00 p.m. Pacific time on August 1, 2026, the fictional Pine County Project ledger attached as Source A recorded exactly three payments from Example Vendor totaling \$12,450.”

The hypothetical record would identify the speaker's stated knowledge basis, the cutoff time, the fictional source bundle, a version ID, and a SHA-256 file fingerprint. That fingerprint can detect changed bytes; it does not prove the claim is true. This example has no real speaker, oath, notary, or legal effect.

Why test it

The format might reduce quotation disputes, encourage narrower wording, normalize “unknown” and qualification, link sources to an exact statement, and preserve a visible correction history. Controlled oath studies supply a reason to test carefully, but they do not establish results for politicians, voters, public reputation, or notarized interviews.

The defensible claim is **worth testing under safeguards**, not “proven to make politicians honest.” The study must measure harmful effects too: coercion, partisan asymmetry, speaker selection, chilled speech, privacy concern, and the mistaken belief that notarization proves truth.

Legal limits that must stay attached

- Notarization does not certify factual truth.
- A false answer does not automatically establish perjury or any other crime.
- Possible consequences depend on exact elements, evidence, jurisdiction, constitutional limits, and official discretion.
- Government truth adjudication, candidate badges, censure, complaint burdens, and public nonsigner lists present serious constitutional risk.
- DGG's private-actor status, entity, funding, control relationships, contacts, distribution plan, forms, and data architecture have not yet been verified.

Washington law identifies oath, verification, false-swearing, and perjury questions worth researching. No located controlling case decides that the proposed private political-media format triggers criminal liability. The project must be valuable even if nobody is investigated or prosecuted.

What Phase 0 permits

The current phase may use only fictional materials without a real signer, oath, or notarial act. A separate private, in-person Washington test using literally true statements about the test itself is a possible future branch only after a reviewed supersession closes the remand and all professional and internal gates are satisfied.

It does not permit a named candidate or public figure, promotional launch, candidate outreach, livestream, remote DGG act, public participation status, truth verdict, or criminal-enforcement claim.

The present request

Reviewers are asked to spend about 10 minutes, first paraphrase the idea without looking back, then answer whether they understood that:

1. participation and each answer are optional;
2. DGG publishes no participation status or adverse inference;
3. the notary does not certify factual truth;
4. a false answer does not automatically prove a crime or trigger prosecution; and
5. this is research, not a live candidate program.

Then identify legal, privacy, accessibility, coercion, evidence, or partisan-symmetry problems. Do not provide confidential or identifying information.

External-release blocker: [approved response form/email], [responsible owner/contact], [accessibility contact], and [deadline] must be completed before this brief is distributed outside transparent repository review.

For detail, read the `information packet`, `research memorandum`, `facts and evidence packet`, and `authority register`.

Part II - Detailed Explainer

What this is - and is not

This proposal is	This proposal is not
An optional format for a speaker's own narrow factual commitments	A government or private "ministry of truth"
A provenance record: who signed what, when, in which exact version, with which sources	A notary-certified fact-check
A test of whether clearer boundaries improve precision, corrections, and audience understanding	A promise that an oath makes politicians honest
A way to separate fact from unsworn commentary	A demand that opinions, predictions, or advocacy be sworn
A system with "unknown," qualification, correction, and exit paths	A perjury trap or automatic criminal referral
Candidate-neutral research using fictional or tightly controlled test material	A refusal list, candidate badge, participation score, or ballot label

DGG will draw and publish no adverse inference from nonparticipation. Because DGG cannot control third-party political reactions, Phase 0 publishes no invitation, participation, refusal, or nonresponse status.

How a later approved record could work

1. Admit only a suitable factual proposition

A proposed sworn statement should identify:

- the person or thing being described;
- the relevant time period;
- one checkable predicate;
- the speaker's basis of knowledge;
- any necessary definition or qualification;
- the permitted answers, including "unknown" or a written qualification; and
- the sources the speaker wants attached.

Predictions, value judgments, slogans, broad policy interpretations, compound accusations, and questions that require guessing stay in the unsworn lane.

2. Freeze one exact record before the act

The speaker receives the exact wording and source bundle in advance. The record receives a version identifier and a SHA-256 cryptographic file fingerprint, which can detect changed bytes but does not prove substantive truth. The speaker may correct, qualify, decline, or move the subject to ordinary conversation before signing.

3. Keep the roles separate

- The **speaker** owns the substantive answer and stated basis of knowledge.
- DGG or another **publisher** designs the editorial format and preserves the record.
- **Counsel** reviews the statement, notice, release, and applicable law.
- The **notary** independently controls the notarial act and may refuse or stop as law permits.
- A later **fact-checker or audience** may assess the claim, but that assessment is not the notarial act.

4. Preserve, do not rewrite, corrections

A substantive change after execution would require a new record and new act. The earlier version would remain linked and clearly superseded rather than silently edited. Whether a correction has any legal effect would depend on the applicable law and facts; the project promises no immunity.

Annotated synthetic demonstration

The following is fictional. It is a paper-design example only. No person made this statement, no notary administered an oath, and no legal conclusion should be drawn from it.

Synthetic claim unit SR-EX-001 Prompt: “As of 5:00 p.m. Pacific time on August 1, 2026, did the fictional Pine County Project ledger attached as Source A record exactly three payments from Example Vendor totaling \$12,450?” **Selected response:** Yes. **Final statement placed in the record:** “As of 5:00 p.m. Pacific time on August 1, 2026, the fictional Pine County Project ledger attached as Source A recorded exactly three payments from Example Vendor totaling \$12,450.”

Field	Synthetic content	Why it exists
Speaker	Jordan Lee, a fictional project treasurer	Identifies the declarant without using a real participant
Knowledge basis	Custodian of the fictional ledger; reviewed entries 101 - 103	Makes personal knowledge explicit
Permitted response path	“Yes,” “No,” “I do not know,” or written qualification; the final proposition must match the selected path	Prevents pressured guessing and makes the signed proposition exact
Scope	One ledger, three entries, one cutoff time	Avoids a vague claim such as “our finances are accurate”
Source bundle	Fictional Source A plus a source manifest	Lets readers inspect the cited basis
Record version	SR-EX-001 v1; SHA-256 file fingerprint shown on the record	Detects post-signing byte changes; does not prove truth
Jurat	Placeholder only; exact act and certificate require counsel/requester selection and lawful notary completion	Avoids asking the notary to choose DGG's legal form
Public disclaimer	“The notary did not verify the ledger or the amount.”	Blocks the most dangerous misconception
Correction	A later v2 would link to v1 and explain the change	Preserves history and context

This design does not prove the claim. It makes the speaker's exact commitment and supporting material easier to identify and audit.

Why the proposal may be worth testing

The strongest case for the format does not depend on anyone being prosecuted. A carefully designed record could provide:

- fewer moving clips and paraphrase disputes;
- narrower factual wording and explicit definitions;
- a visible “unknown” option instead of a pressured guess;
- a source bundle tied to the exact statement;
- a correction history that preserves what changed;
- a clean boundary between factual commitment and ordinary advocacy; and
- measurable evidence about audience comprehension and speaker behavior.

Laboratory and online studies have found that some honesty-oath formulations changed reporting behavior, while other formulations had weaker or nonsignificant effects. None of the located studies tested politicians, adversarial interviews, public

reputation, notarization, or voter understanding. The defensible conclusion is **“worth testing under safeguards,” not “proven to work.”** See `EMP-TRUST-01` and the empirical source summaries in `report-source.md`.

The legal idea - and its limits

Washington law recognizes administering an oath and taking a verification on oath or affirmation as notarial acts. A verification is the signer's declaration, under oath, that a statement in a record is true. Washington also has false-swearing and perjury statutes with different elements. These statutes identify legal questions worth testing. They do not establish that this private format triggers false-swearing or perjury liability in any particular case.

It does not supply a shortcut:

- Notarization is not substantive truth verification.
- A false answer is not automatically perjury.
- Potential false swearing depends on a knowingly false statement under an oath required or authorized by law; exact application to private political speech remains constitutionally and factually unresolved.
- First-degree perjury has additional materiality and official-proceeding requirements.
- Jurisdiction, admissible proof, charging discretion, limitations, and interstate process are independent questions.
- A private organization cannot create a prosecution by contract or branding.

Political speech also receives unusually strong constitutional protection. Washington's leading campaign-speech decisions and the U.S. Supreme Court's false-speech cases strongly caution against a government truth tribunal, broad complaint process, censure system, or public stigma for declining. A government-adjacent version would create additional forum, disclosure, public-records, and equal-treatment questions. The present Phase 0 is a private, nonpublic, candidate-neutral fictional mock with no signer, oath, or notarial act. DGG's legal entity, funding, control relationships, and government contacts remain unverified launch gates.

The detailed analysis and adverse authority are in the `research memorandum`, `authority register`, and `gap matrix`.

What Phase 0 actually permits

Phase 0 is a safety and comprehension test, not a political launch. While the remand remains open, it may use only:

- a pure mock using fictional material, with no real signer, oath, or notarial act.

A private Washington in-person test limited to literally true statements about the test itself is a possible future branch, not current permission. It would require a reviewed supersession closing the remand as well as every written professional gate.

Phase 0 does not permit:

- a named candidate, officeholder, or public-figure target;
- promotional distribution, candidate outreach, or publication presented as an approved program; the repository copy is visible only as a review draft;
- a livestream or free-form “everything is now under oath” interview;
- a remote DGG act;
- a candidate badge, scorecard, invitation list, or refusal/nonresponse label;
- a statement that a participant committed a crime; or
- use of a notarial journal, identity credential, or statutory notarial recording as a DGG publicity asset.

How the idea should be evaluated

The first release gate is comprehension, not enthusiasm. Intended readers should be able to explain, in their own words, that:

1. participation and question-level answers are optional;

2. DGG draws and publishes no adverse inference from declining and publishes no participation status in Phase 0;
3. the notary does not certify factual truth;
4. a false response does not automatically prove perjury or guarantee prosecution; and
5. the current project is research, not a live candidate program.

A proposed project rule is at least 90% correct comprehension on each of those high-risk propositions in a preregistered test, with no meaningful increase in “notarized means verified true” or “declining means dishonest” relative to neutral control copy. That is a safety recommendation, not a legal standard or a claim that 90% is universally optimal.

Other outcomes should include:

- unaided main-message recall;
- coercion or unfair-surprise perception;
- qualification, unknown, decline, and correction rates;
- partisan-symmetry and selection measures;
- false-confidence rate;
- accessibility and reading burden;
- privacy or security incidents; and
- evidence that the format improves precision without chilling protected speech.

Frequently asked questions

Is the notary saying the claim is true?

No. The signer makes the declaration. The notary checks required identity and signature, administers the oath or affirmation, and completes the notarial certificate. The notary is not DGG's fact-checker or spokesperson.

Is every false answer perjury?

No. Washington crimes have different elements, and their application depends on the exact statement, knowledge, materiality where required, kind of proceeding, authorization of the oath, jurisdiction, evidence, and official discretion. The project must never advertise an automatic felony.

Why use an oath at all?

The testable theory is that a formal, exact, source-linked commitment may improve care, provenance, correction, or audience calibration. If the project has value only when viewers expect prosecution, it should stop.

What if a person declines?

DGG will draw and publish no adverse inference about honesty. People may decline for scheduling, legal, strategic, privacy, religious, or format reasons. Because DGG cannot control third-party political reactions, the current project publishes no invitation, participation, refusal, or nonresponse status.

Would government run the program?

Not in the current recommended design. A government or public-private version would require a new constitutional, forum, disclosure, public-records, retention, and election-law analysis. It could not simply inherit the private Phase 0 conclusions.

Is this already proven to improve political truth?

No. The empirical evidence comes from different tasks and populations. Political-speaker and audience effects - including harmful effects - must be tested directly.

What is the safest name for the idea?

Use “**voluntary source-linked sworn-record format**” or “**voluntary factual-commitment record**.” Avoid “truth-certified,” “notary-verified truth,” “lie detector,” “perjury trap,” and “official truth pledge.”

Current request to reviewers

Reviewers are being asked to do only three things:

1. mark any sentence that implies the notary verified truth, declining implies dishonesty, or criminal enforcement is automatic;
2. paraphrase the proposal without looking back at this packet; and
3. identify missing legal, operational, privacy, accessibility, or partisan-symmetry risks.

No reviewer is being asked to sign, swear, recruit a candidate, endorse legislation, or approve a live pilot.

Review time: approximately 10 minutes. **Response sequence:** first submit an unaided paraphrase; then answer the five comprehension questions; then provide optional comments. **Privacy:** do not include confidential, privileged, or identifying material. No session may be recorded without a separate approved consent process and a nonrecorded option. **Release blocker:** an approved response form or email, responsible owner, accessibility contact, and deadline must replace these fields before any external distribution: [form/email], [owner/contact], [deadline].